

ABOVE ALL ELSE SHOW THE DATA.

EDWARD R. TUFTE

Inkwell

A Tufte-Style Book

With a VDQI Title and Contents Page

FIRST EDITION

Measured One Press

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*Dedicated to readers who prefer evidence,
proportion, and quiet pages.*

Part I

Visual Evidence

The Design of Analytical Pages

THE PAGES of an analytical book should carry evidence with as little ceremony as possible. Tufte’s book design gives the main text a calm measure while reserving the margin for sidenotes, captions, and small annotations.

This demo compiles from Markdown through Pandoc (MacFarlane 2023), while the template supplies the VDQI-inspired title page and contents styling from the downloaded LaTeX source.

The important structural convention is simple: with `top-level-division: chapter`, each top-level Markdown heading becomes a book chapter. Raw LaTeX `\part{...}` commands may be placed between chapters to create large divisions in the table of contents.

The template uses `tufte-book`, so ordinary footnotes become sidenotes and margin notes can be placed explicitly.

A Compact Comparison

The front matter differs from the default Inkwell title page in three visible ways: the author’s name sits at the top, the title appears just above the page center, and the publisher rests at the bottom margin.

Table 1: Title page structure used by the Tufte Book VDQI template.

Element	VDQI-style treatment
Author	Serif italic at the top of the page
Title	Large serif title above center
Edition	Small caps sans serif below the title
Publisher	Serif italic at the bottom margin

The book template keeps the visual language of the handout template, but it adds front matter, back matter, parts, chapters, and a table of contents tuned for longer work. In practical use, this means that the same Inkwell document can grow from a short technical note into a coherent manual or monograph without changing the authoring format.

Full-width passages can span the main text and margin when the argument needs more horizontal space. Use them sparingly; the extra width is most effective when it lets a table, figure, or short aside breathe.

Chapter Structure from Markdown

A TUFTE-STYLE BOOK in Inkwell is compiled as one Markdown source file today. The compiler sends that file through Pandoc, Pandoc turns

the top-level headings into chapters, and the LaTeX template handles the book front matter and layout.

That does not mean the book must feel like a single long article. Parts, chapters, sections, tables, figures, margin notes, and citations all work together inside one source file. The table below shows the authoring pattern.

Table 2: Common source patterns for a Tufte Book VDQI document.

Markdown or LaTeX source	Book result
<code>\part{Visual Evidence}</code>	Part entry in the contents
<code># Chapter Title</code>	Numbered chapter
<code>## Section Title</code>	Section inside the chapter
<code>\marginnote{...}</code>	Unnumbered note in the margin
<code>\begin{fullwidth}</code>	Text block across the main text and margin

If you prefer to draft chapters in separate files, the current extension does not yet assemble a folder of Markdown chapters automatically. The reliable workflow is to compile a master Markdown document. A future multi-file book mode could add a `frontmatter chapters: list` and concatenate those files before Pandoc runs.

The blank margin figure above is intentional: it keeps the demo self-contained without requiring an external asset. In a real book, replace the framed rule with `\includegraphics[width=\linewidth]{path/to/figure.pdf}`

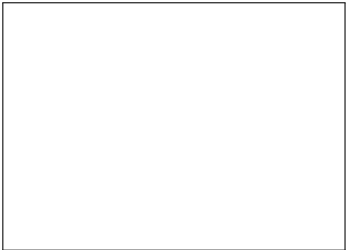


Figure 1: A margin figure can hold a small image, sparkline, or schematic beside the chapter text.

Part II

Margin and Measure

Sidenotes and Citations

MARGIN MATERIAL lets supporting context travel beside the sentence that needs it. This is especially useful for source notes, short definitions, and small clarifications. The extension's code and citation pipeline follow the same Markdown workflow as the other templates (Knuth 1984).

Fenced aside blocks become Tufte margin notes for short, single-paragraph comments.

Longer arguments still belong in the main text. The margin is best treated as a parallel channel, not a second essay.

Numbered Sidenotes

Ordinary Markdown footnotes compile as LaTeX footnotes, and the Tufte class places them in the margin.¹ Use this style for notes that are part of the reading sequence.

¹ This is a numbered sidenote produced from a Markdown footnote.

Use `\marginnote{...}` for unnumbered asides, labels, and small reminders. Use numbered sidenotes when the note should have a visible anchor in the main text. Both styles are useful, but they should not be mixed casually on every sentence.

Citations in the Margin Style

Pandoc citeproc keeps bibliography handling consistent across templates. A book chapter can cite software, articles, reports, or books using the same `[@key]` syntax used by shorter Inkwell documents (MacFarlane 2023).

The generated references appear wherever the bibliography heading is placed in the Markdown source. In this demo the references heading sits at the end of the book, after the final chapter.

Full-Width Displays

THE MAIN TEXT COLUMN is intentionally narrow. It improves reading rhythm, but some comparisons need more width. Tufte layouts solve this by allowing occasional full-width material.

| Page element | Best use | Caution | |—————|—————|—————| | Main text | Narrative, argument, definitions | Keep paragraphs concise | | Margin note | Local context, short citations, reminders | Avoid multi-paragraph notes | | Full-width block | Wide tables, dense comparisons, larger figures | Use sparingly | | Part page | Major conceptual division | Do not over-segment a short work |
: Choosing the right page region for analytical content.

The full-width table appears in the flow of the chapter, but it occupies the same horizontal measure as the body plus margin. This is helpful for comparative material that would otherwise become cramped or hard to scan.

The same pattern works for a figure. Wrap a normal LaTeX figure or Markdown table in `fullwidth` only when the extra space improves the reader's ability to see the structure.

Part III

A Small Demonstration Book

From Notes to Chapters

A USEFUL BOOK DEMO should contain enough structure to prove that front matter, parts, chapters, and lists are working. This chapter is written only to make that structure visible in the compiled PDF.

In an actual project, you might use the first part to establish concepts, the second part to present evidence, and the third part to collect methods or appendices. The Tufte Book VDQI template does not impose that organization; it only makes the organization visible.

A Drafting Rhythm

One practical rhythm is to start every chapter with a `\newthought{...}` phrase, then place the first margin note only after the chapter's purpose is clear. The reader should not have to choose between reading the main text and reading the margin before the chapter has begun.

After the opening paragraph, ordinary sections can carry the chapter forward. The top-level heading creates the chapter; second-level headings create the sections that appear inside that chapter.

Margin notes work best when they reward attention without becoming required for basic comprehension.

A Longer Paragraph Block

This paragraph exists to make the compiled demo feel more like a book page than a template smoke test. A book layout should demonstrate line length, margin balance, heading spacing, footnote placement, table captions, and the visual distance between adjacent chapters. These details are hard to judge from a two-page sample because the table of contents has almost nothing to list and the page rhythm never has time to settle.

The point of a longer demo is not filler for its own sake. It creates enough surface area to catch integration problems: a contents entry that wraps badly, a chapter heading that starts too close to the top margin, a long table that does not belong in the main measure, or a sidenote that collides with another piece of marginal material.

A Reproducible Book Workflow

THE INKWELL WORKFLOW keeps source text, code outputs, figures, and bibliography files under one project root. For a book, the same principle applies: keep the manuscript in Markdown, keep generated artifacts in `.inkwell/`, and let the compiler produce the PDF in an isolated build directory.

The current template expects the book manuscript to be one Mark-down document. That is the most predictable path because Pandoc sees the whole table of contents, all cross-references, and all citations in one run.

Possible Future Multi-File Mode

A multi-file mode would be a good future extension: a master file could declare chapter files in frontmatter, and Inkwell could assemble those files before calling Pandoc.

```
chapters:
- chapters/01-pages.md
- chapters/02-sidenotes.md
- chapters/03-workflow.md
```

That feature is not required for the template to work, but it would make larger books easier to maintain. Until then, the single master document is the working model.

References

- [] Knuth, Donald E. 1984. "Literate Programming." *The Computer Journal* 27 (2): 97–111. <https://doi.org/10.1093/comjnl/27.2.97>.
- [] MacFarlane, John. 2023. *Pandoc: A Universal Document Converter*. Released. <https://pandoc.org>.